The Modern Man

On his advent to power, Honecker assembled a tight circle of friends, family, and ‘yes-men’ advisers to draw personal support and counsel. Access to his orbit fell to Elli Kelm, a short, mousy-haired woman who had served as his gatekeeper since 1952, successfully keeping away whingers and hangers-on. She was considered a formidable presence, or as one security official remarked, ‘the Cerberus standing guard outside his office door who stopped everyone except Heinz Hoffmann and Heinz Kessler, and she would have liked to have stopped them too’.

Predictably, Margot’s position as Minister of Education was secure, while her brother, Manfred Feist – a man described by Markus Wolf as an ‘incompetent functionary’ – was elected to the Central Committee. From here on, Honecker’s ‘core team’ consisted of Alfred Neumann, Stoph’s deputy; Paul Verner, whom he brought into the Central Committee as secretary for security; Werner Lamberz, who was to lend a hand to the aging Albert Norden; Hermann Axen, responsible for foreign policy within the International Liaison Department; Werner Krolikowski, and Horst Sindermann.

The crafty State Security Minister Erich Mielke and Harry Tisch – who soon advanced to the head of the trade union federation – became candidates for the Politburo. Advice and support also came from Konrad Naumann, Ingeburg Lange, Werner Felfe, Joachim Hermann and Heinz Kessler, all close friends from his FDJ days. ‘New faces, that was not his thing,’ says Schabowski. ‘Once established, they stayed. This also applied to the Politburo. Any change in the group would raise speculation about rivalries.’ However, a new appointment came when Egon Krenz was installed as leader of the Ernst Thälmann Pioneer Organisation. Cheekily described as ‘horse face’ by detractors, Honecker considered Krenz of pleasing appearance and manner – he even had the makings of a successor. ‘Honecker’s comradely relationship with me impressed me,’ Krenz remembered. ‘It was heartfelt and productive.’1